

INSTITUTIONAL
INVESTOR



11th Annual Redefining Fixed Income Forum

May 13, 2025
Four Seasons Hotel
Chicago, IL



On May 13, 2025, the Redefining Fixed Income Forum will convene in Chicago, bringing together leading investors from insurance funds and pension plans to navigate the shifting landscape of fixed income. With the Federal Reserve initiating interest rate cuts for the first time since 2020, asset allocators are faced with both opportunities and challenges in an evolving market.

The backdrop of next year's forum is complex: as speculation around inflation resurges and the health of the US economy remains in question, the low-income consumer grapples with increasing financial strain. Attendees will delve into critical discussions surrounding the impact of these economic dynamics on fixed income portfolios—exploring whether risk spreads will widen, the potential for a soft or hard landing, and the implications for a possible recession.

Key themes include strategic asset allocation decisions: where to invest amidst tightening spreads—be it asset-backed, higher-risk, or long-duration assets. Participants will also assess untapped opportunities in the credit market and identify which investment managers possess the necessary infrastructure, expertise, and scale to enhance their clients' fixed income returns.

In addition to thought-provoking presentations and panel discussions, the forum will offer ample networking opportunities for participants to engage with peers, share insights, and collaborate on innovative investment strategies. The Redefining Fixed Income Forum promises to be an essential gathering for industry leaders to redefine their approach to fixed income in a transformative economic climate.

2025 Sponsors

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2025 Advisory Board

Institutional Investor would like to thank the esteemed advisory members for their invaluable support and guidance in shaping our 11th Annual Redefining Fixed Income Forum.

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Chirag Gandhi, *Portfolio Manager, Fixed Income, North Dakota Retirement & Investment Office*

Tunc Dayioglu, *Managing Analyst, State of Wisconsin Investment Board*

Agenda

Tuesday May 13, 2024

8:00 – 8:45 AM

Registration & Breakfast
Lakeview Foyer

8:45 – 8:50 AM

Opening Remarks & App Tutorial
Lakeview Junior Ballroom

Everything attendees need can be found on our app, including program details, speaker biographies, benchmarking survey results, attendee list, white papers, and access to the speaker presentations we have been authorized to make available.

8:50 – 9:00 AM

Chairperson's Welcome & Benchmarking Session
Lakeview Junior Ballroom

Forum Chairperson:

Thanos Papasavvas, CFA, Founder & Chief Investment Officer, **ABP Invest Ltd.**

What are the issues, concerns, and primary interests of your peers – investment decision-makers from the larger pension plans, endowments, and foundations? In this opening session and in subsequent sessions, attendees will be polled on several high-interest topics using an anonymous, interactive electronic response system. By doing this, we will provide all attendees with useful benchmarks and unique insight into the concerns of investors. We will also strive to tee up certain points of discussion for subsequent sessions.

9:00 – 9:40 AM

Panel: How are Investors Adapting Their Fixed Income Allocations in Reaction to the Uptick in Global Tariffs and Fed Rate and US Policy Unpredictability?
Lakeview Junior Ballroom

We seem to be in the midst of a major shift in the areas of geopolitics, trade and US fiscal policy. In addition, further FOMC rate cuts have become akin to a moving target, rather than a foregone conclusion. In spite of recent US Treasury yield volatility, spreads still remain very tight, to the point that high yield probably needs to be renamed.

- How do investors see the current and potential future state of the US and global economies and how is it impacting portfolio construction?
- What do investors' crystal balls tell them about the direction of rates and how are they positioning their portfolios accordingly?
- Do elevated debt levels among the government, corporations, and consumers in the US worry investors and where they are seeking yield and risk exposure?
- What will be the effects of policies under the new Presidential Administration and Congress?
- What regulatory shifts are potentially affecting financial markets and fixed income securities?
- How are allocators adapting to the ongoing risk of inflation and is transitory or structural?
- When will spreads begin to widen?
- Will geopolitical tensions rise, and how will that influence allocation decisions?

Moderator:

Greg Leonberger, Director of Research, Managing Partner, **Marquette Associates**

Panelists:

Nzidia Arriaga, Head of Fixed Income Investments, **AAA - The Auto Club**

Chirag Gandhi, Portfolio Manager, Fixed Income, **North Dakota Retirement & Investment**

Ruth Farrugia, Chief Investment Officer, **Resolution Life**

Michael Shearer, Head of Fixed Income Strategies, **State of Wisconsin Investment Board**

Additional speakers to be announced.

9:40 – 9:50 AM**Tabletop discussions**

Lakeview Junior Ballroom

Seated in small groups, attendees will share their perspectives, insights, and questions on the topics discussed during the panel. This format allows for deeper exploration of key themes, fosters meaningful dialogue among participants, and encourages collaborative problem-solving. Attendees will have the chance to connect with peers, exchange ideas, and gain valuable perspectives from diverse viewpoints.

9:50 – 10:30 AM**Breakout sessions:**

Attendees will split into two tracks, each focused on a key topic, allowing you to choose the session most relevant to your interests.

Breakout I

LaSalle A

Panel: Asset-Backed Securities: Risks, Rewards, and Strategies

Asset-backed securities (ABS) offer a great opportunity for allocators to diversify risk by investing in a slice of income streams from various underlying assets. However, the complexity and quality of the underlying assets can significantly affect the performance and risk of ABS. This discussion will cover:

- What are some of the more interesting assets backing securities that allocators are capitalizing on today?
- What are key due diligence factors that allocators and managers are implementing to assess the credit risk of the underlying assets and the borrowers?
- What are some of the common credit enhancements that allocators are seeing in these structures today? How are they mitigating risk and what are the complexities of the structures?
- Are managers tranching new ABS issuances and if so, which tranches are most enticing among the insurers and pension funds?
- What has been the performance in ABS over cycle and are the underlying assets facing any headwinds that could disrupt credit quality or cash flow?

Moderator:

Panelists:

Evan Shay, VP, Securitized Credit Analyst, Fixed Income Division, **T. Rowe Price**

Additional speakers to be announced.

Breakout II

LaSalle B

Proposed Panel: Is the Projected \$200 trillion Infrastructure Supercycle Grounded in Fact and Are Allocators Chomping at the Bit to Invest?

According to some in the asset management world, infrastructure financing demand will surpass \$200 trillion over the next three decades for projects focused on digitalization, decarbonization, and deglobalization. Once considered a more specialized asset class, infrastructure is gradually making its way into the mainstream of institutional portfolios. This panel will explore the opportunities and complexities of infrastructure debt, including:

- From plain vanilla to high tech, what are the types of infrastructure projects that are seeking financing?
- What are the different types of debt instruments, vehicles and financing models for these projects?
- How are cash flows from infrastructure projects modeled, including considerations for operational stability, regulatory support, and revenue predictability?
- What are the drivers behind this massive investment projection, including policy, technology, and global trends?
- How are managers navigating credit and default risks?
- What are the main risks that should be thoroughly scrutinized in the due diligence process?
 - Creditworthiness of infrastructure project
 - Regulatory stability
 - Project execution risks
 - Economic cycles

10:30 – 11:00 AM

Networking Coffee Break

Lakeview Foyer

11:00 – 11:40 AM

Panel: Bank vs. Non-Bank Loan Allocations: What Role Does Each Play and How Should They Co-Exist in an Institutional Portfolio?

Lakeview Junior Ballroom

Non-bank lending, such as middle market private credit, has been the darling of the investment world for the past few years, having grown to approximately \$1.5T. However, many speculate that the asset class has yet to be battle tested in a true credit cycle. The US senior loan market is equally as large and is underwritten according to different parameters, however, it has lagged in attention. The US economy remains strong, supporting the resilience of both asset classes, but where and when would investors prefer to be allocated to one versus the other?

- How do the underwriting standards between the two contrast and why?
- How have each held up during different credit cycles?
- Are either of these asset classes at risk of oversaturation?
- What is the ideal allocation of each within an institutional portfolio and what roles does each play in terms of risk, return and longevity?

Moderator:

Serge Agres, Managing Director, Pensions Practice, **Cambridge Associates**

Panelists:

To be confirmed, **Nuveen**

Audie Apple, Senior Vice president, Direct Lending Institutional Portfolio Manager, **Fidelity Investments**

Additional speakers to be announced.

11:40 AM – 12:00 PM**Fireside Chat/Presentation****A Scientific Approach to Fixed Income Management***Lakeview Junior Ballroom***Presented by:**Alex Khein, Chief Executive Officer, **BlueCove**

12:00 – 12:40 PM**Panel: Are the Trump Tariffs and Concerns Over Trade Wars Overblown and is International Fixed Income Resilient Enough to Withstand the Threats?***Lakeview Junior Ballroom*

The Trump Administration has proved that tariffs are, indeed, on the table. This has led many investors to rethink their allocation to non-US assets, including fixed income:

- What are allocators doing to hedge their portfolios against increased volatility in fixed income assets?
- Are tight spreads in areas such as high yield causing allocators to look towards non-US fixed income?
- Which non-US countries or regions have attractive yields and resilient economies relative to economies such as Canada, who are lowering rates and are showing signs of economic weakness?
- What kinds of sectors and companies have strong balance sheets, growth prospects and low correlation to US markets?
- Have we seen the peak of US exceptionalism? What role do non-US fixed income assets play in institutional portfolios relative to US fixed income assets?

Moderator:

To be announced.

Panelists:Roberto Sanchez-Dahl, Managing Director, Senior Portfolio Manager, Emerging Markets, **Manulife Investment Management**Peter Kent, Co-Head of Emerging Market Fixed Income, **Ninety One***Additional speakers to be announced.*

12:40 PM – 2:00 PM**Seated Lunch***Adorn*

2:00 – 2:40 PM**Panel: What are the Pros and Cons of Public versus Private Fixed Income in the Current Investment Environment?***Lakeview Junior Ballroom*

The pursuit of yield while managing risk is an ongoing challenge for allocators. They need to weigh various factors to find the best opportunities, including:

- Which asset class do allocators favor in a market with such compressed yields?
- Can market inefficiencies lead to better valuation opportunities in one market versus the other?
- Where can investors find more attractive risk-adjusted returns?
- What impact do economic conditions have on allocation?
- Do private markets offer greater control over covenants, allowing for more tailored risk management?
- What are the liquidity considerations between the two asset classes?
- Is there excessive market saturation in the private markets? Is there too much capital chasing limited deals?
- How do public versus private markets react to economic cycles and are managers battle-tested in case of economic turbulence?
- How do default rates, recovery rates, and other risk metrics compare between the two?
- Are some private fixed income strategies fraught with risk for LPs because they are essentially kicking the can down the road for certain investments?

Moderator:

Frank Valle, Associate Director of Fixed Income, **Marquette Associates, Inc.**

Panelists:

Speaker to be confirmed, **Allspring Global Investments**

Joe Rumph, Managing Director, Fixed Income and Alpha Strategies, **MacArthur Foundation**

Joseph A. Maietta, Managing Director, **New York Life Investments**

Katie DellaMaria, Senior Portfolio Manager, Global Income Strategies, **Teachers' Retirement System at the State of Illinois**

Additional speakers to be announced.

2:40 – 3:20 PM

Panel: In a World of Growing Fixed Income Investment Options, How are Allocators Approaching to Multi-Sector Credit Strategies?

Lakeview Junior Ballroom

The practice of working in silos is a thing of the past. Investment teams must work together and invest across various fixed income sectors to optimize risk-adjusted returns. The panel will discuss how they successfully accomplish that, discussing issues such as:

- Which strategies are allocators using to spread investments across fixed income sectors such as high yield, investment grade, emerging markets, and structured credit to achieve a balanced portfolio?
- What techniques are being used to assess and manage credit risk across multiple sectors, including the use of credit ratings, covenant analysis, and ongoing credit surveillance?
- What are the liquidity considerations when investing in less liquid sectors or assets, and methods to manage liquidity risk?
- What role do derivatives such as swaps, options, and futures in enhancing returns or managing risks within a multi-sector approach?
- What is the role of structured products in providing exposure to unique credit opportunities?

Moderator:

Colleen Brown, Senior Associate Investment Consultant, **Mercer**

Panelists:

Jonathan E. Cordo, SVP, Global Portfolio Solutions, **Brandywine Global**

Damien McCann, Fixed Income Portfolio Manager, **Capital Group**

Tyler Thorn, Principal, Portfolio Manager - Multi-Sector Team, **PGIM Fixed Income**

Xiaowei Han, VP, Head of ALM, **TIAA**

3:20 – 3:30 PM

Tabletop Discussions

Lakeview Junior Ballroom

Seated in small groups, attendees will share their perspectives, insights, and questions on the topics discussed during the panel. This format allows for deeper exploration of key themes, fosters meaningful dialogue among participants, and encourages collaborative problem-solving. Attendees will have the chance to connect with peers, exchange ideas, and gain valuable perspectives from diverse viewpoints.

3:30 – 3:50 PM

Networking Coffee Break

Lakeview Foyer

3:50 – 4:30 PM

Panel: Mastering Manager Selection in Fixed Income: What are Key Considerations for Allocators?

Lakeview Junior Ballroom

Selecting the right investment manager is crucial for achieving desired outcomes in fixed income portfolios, especially in a landscape fraught with volatility and change. Panelists will discuss key considerations, including:

- What are best practices for ongoing surveillance of investment managers, including regular performance reviews and compliance checks? What role does technology play?
- What evaluation process to evaluate a manager's underwriting process do allocators employ to ensure alignment with risk tolerance and investment strategy?
- What are the nuanced approaches towards credit analysis, risk assessment, and deal structuring between different managers and what have allocators gleaned from these varying approaches?
- Is it challenging to find managers that have historically been successful in navigating through market downturns or crises? What are the right questions to ask through the vetting process to make sure that they are well-equipped? Do they have the adaptability to pivot when conditions change suddenly and drastically?
- What are some red flags that allocators should look out for through the manager vetting process?

Moderator:

Hoa Quach, Director, Public Market Investments, **Wespath Benefits and Investments**

Panelists:

Peggy Huang, Chief Investment Officer, **SiriusPoint**

Constance Christian, CFA, Manager, Fixed Income, **Wespath Benefits and Investments**

Additional speakers to be announced.

4:30 – 5:00 PM

Allocators' Panel Discussion

A Look at the Fixed Income Horizon as We March Ahead Into 2026

Lakeview Junior Ballroom

- What does the trajectory of interest rates look like over the next 12 months?
- What do the economic growth forecasts suggest for the remainder of 2025 and 2026?
- Will we see a widening of credit spreads?
- Will allocators want to add more duration in their portfolios?
- Will EMD become a greater part of institutional allocations?
- Are market liquidity risks on the horizon?
- Which new asset classes might we see crop up in the fixed income space?

Moderator:

To be announced.

Panelists:

To be announced.

5:00 – 6:00 PM

Cocktail Reception

Delaware and Delaware Foyer

Unwind and conclude the day by connecting with peers, fostering meaningful conversations and networking.